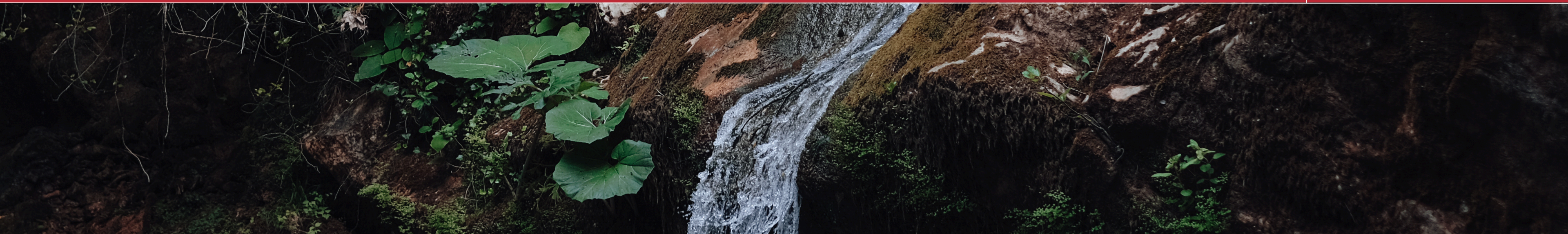
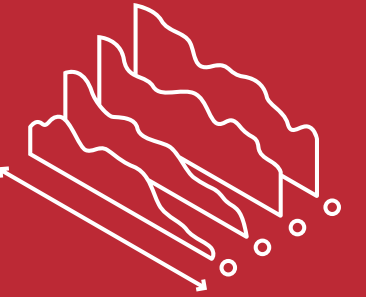


“I knew how to report, but didn’t”

Awareness, Helplessness, and Platform Distrust in CSAM Reporting Among Youth

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Problem Statement

The NCMEC CyberTipline received 36.2 million reports in 2023, up from 18.4 million in 2018, a 97% surge over five years.¹

In Canada, Cybertip.ca processed over 40,000 public reports in 2023, a 45% increase from 2022.² Online sexual luring reports received by Cybertip.ca rose by more than 815% between 2018 and 2022.³

“A 2023 Stanford Internet Observatory investigation found 500+ accounts on Instagram advertising self-generated CSAM with tens of thousands of likely buyers.”

DiResta & Thiel, Stanford Law School (2023)⁶

Since this study's data collection in March–April 2024, the problem has intensified. The Internet Watch Foundation's 2026 AI CSAM Report identified 8,029 AI-generated images and videos of realistic child sexual abuse in 2025.

This is a 14% increase year-over-year. AI abuse videos alone rose from 13 in 2024 to 3,440 in 2025: a 26,362% increase.⁴

How ordinary users experience, respond to, and reason about CSAM encounters on mainstream platforms is largely unexamined in the empirical literature.⁵

¹ NCMEC, 2024 CyberTipline Report (2024)

² CyberTip.ca, Reports From the Public Processed in 2023 (2024)

³ CyberTip.ca / C3P, Safer Internet Day Press Release (2023)

⁴ Internet Watch Foundation, Harm Without Limits: AI CSAM Report (2026)

⁵ Teunissen & Napier, Australian Institute of Criminology (2022)

⁶ DiResta & Thiel, Stanford Internet Observatory / Stanford Law School (2023)

Bill

C-63

Online Harms Act

Canada

Introduced: February 26, 2024¹

Proposed Requirements

- 24-hour mandatory CSAM takedown
- Mandatory outcome notification to reporting users
- Digital Safety Commission of Canada (enforcement powers)
- Mandatory public disclosure of moderation statistics

Bill C-63 died on the order paper, January 2025.¹

Canadian users who report CSAM to platforms currently have no enforceable right to notification of the outcome of their report.

Bill C-16 (introduced December 9, 2025) reprises key elements of C-63's CSAM reporting amendments but remains at second reading as of May 2026.²

STOP CSAM ACT

Strengthening Transparency and Obligations to Protect Children Suffering from Abuse and Mistreatment Act (S.1829 / H.R.3921)

United States

Reintroduced May 21, 2025³

Proposed Requirements

- Mandatory annual transparency reports from large platforms on CyberTipline reporting and moderation action rates
- Civil liability for platforms that knowingly host CSAM
- Stronger CyberTipline reporting requirements

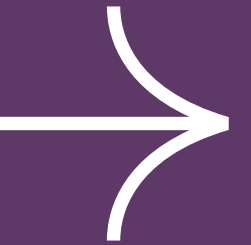
¹ House of Commons, Canada. Bill C-63, 44th Parliament, 1st Session (2024)

² House of Commons, Canada. Bill C-16, 45th Parliament, 1st Session (2025)

³ U.S. Congress. STOP CSAM Act, S.1829, 119th Congress (2025)



Research Questions



RQ1

How prevalent is CSAM exposure among university students, and on which platforms does it occur?

RQ2

What emotional responses and behavioural choices characterise the immediate aftermath of a CSAM encounter, and what explains the gap between knowing how to report and actually doing so?

Methodology

¹ Teunissen & Napier, Australian Institute of Criminology (2022)

Study Design

Design	Cross-sectional anonymous online survey
Period	March 11 – June 10, 2024
Distribution	University of Waterloo

Dimensions Examined

- 1. Prior CSAM exposure on social media
- 2. Platform distribution of encounters
- 3. Emotional reactions and behavioural responses
- 4. Reporting knowledge, behaviour, and perceived platform responsiveness
- 5. Policy preferences for platform accountability

Respondents Demographics

Total respondents, <i>n</i> = 94	
Age Range	18–24 (<i>mean</i> = 21, <i>median</i> = 21)
Gender	Men 44.7% · Women 29.8% · Non-binary 10.6% Not disclosed 10.6% · Other 4.3%

Instrument

15 items: binary, multiple-choice, Likert-type, open-response

Key measures

- Exposure (binary: yes / no / unsure)
- Platform identification (multi-select)
- Emotional reactions and behavioural responses (multi-select)
- Reporting knowledge (binary) and platform response (follow-up)
- Seriousness (0–10)
- Platform adequacy (1–5)
- Reporting effectiveness (0–10)
- Policy preferences (multi-select)

CSAM Definition

Inclusive; any involvement of minors in sexual contexts, covering visual media, online conversations, comments, posts, and related content.

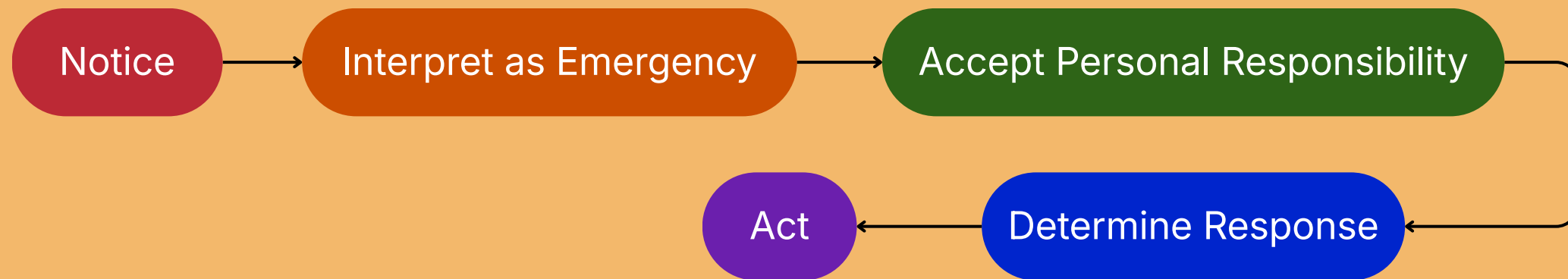
Consistent with research indicating that user-side exposure to CSAM-adjacent content substantially exceeds exposure to content meeting strict legal definitions.¹

Theoretical Framework - I

Bystander Effect

Latané & Darley (1970)¹

Five-Stage Model



Failure at any stage produces non-intervention.¹

Extended to Online Contexts

- Anonymity reduces identifiability and felt obligation²
- Absence of non-verbal cues reduces the signal strength of distress and urgency³
- Platform scale amplifies diffusion of responsibility⁴
- Doubt about reporting efficacy suppresses intervention even when individuals judge the event as harmful⁵
- Self-efficacy regarding platform reporting tools is a significant predictor of whether bystanders act⁴

Core Insight

Responsibility diffuses across larger groups, so the more bystanders present, the less any individual feels obligated to act.¹

¹ Latané & Darley, The Unresponsive Bystander (1970)

² Chan et al., Information Systems Research (2022)

³ Herry & Mulvey, Journal of Social Issues (2022)

⁴ Jeyagobi et al., Frontiers in Public Health (2022)

⁵ Huang et al., Psychology Research and Behavior Management (2023)

Theoretical Framework - II

Learned Helplessness

Seligman (1975)²

Core Insight

Repeated exposure to unresponsive environments generates a generalised expectation of futility, inhibiting action even when action remains available.²

Applied here as Reporting Disenchantment

When prior reporting experiences produce no visible outcome, disenchantment with reporting processes reduces future reporting intention.³

Propagation of Belief among Non-Reporters

A user who has formed a prior belief that platform moderation is unresponsive carries that belief into any future encounter, suppressing reporting even when full procedural knowledge is present.³

Perceived reporting efficacy is the primary predictor of reporting behaviour on social networking sites, more so than procedural knowledge.³

This dynamic parallels privacy fatigue: repeated experiences of inadequate system response lead users to disengage from protective behaviour entirely.⁴

Bystander Effect + Learned Helplessness

These two mechanisms compound: diffusion of responsibility suppresses initial reporting; reporting disenchantment from platform non-response suppresses all future reporting. Together they produce rational disengagement.^{1 2 3}

¹ Latané & Darley, The Unresponsive Bystander (1970)

² Seligman, Helplessness (1975)

³ Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)

⁴ Tian, Chen & Zhang, Applied Sciences (2022)

Finding 01

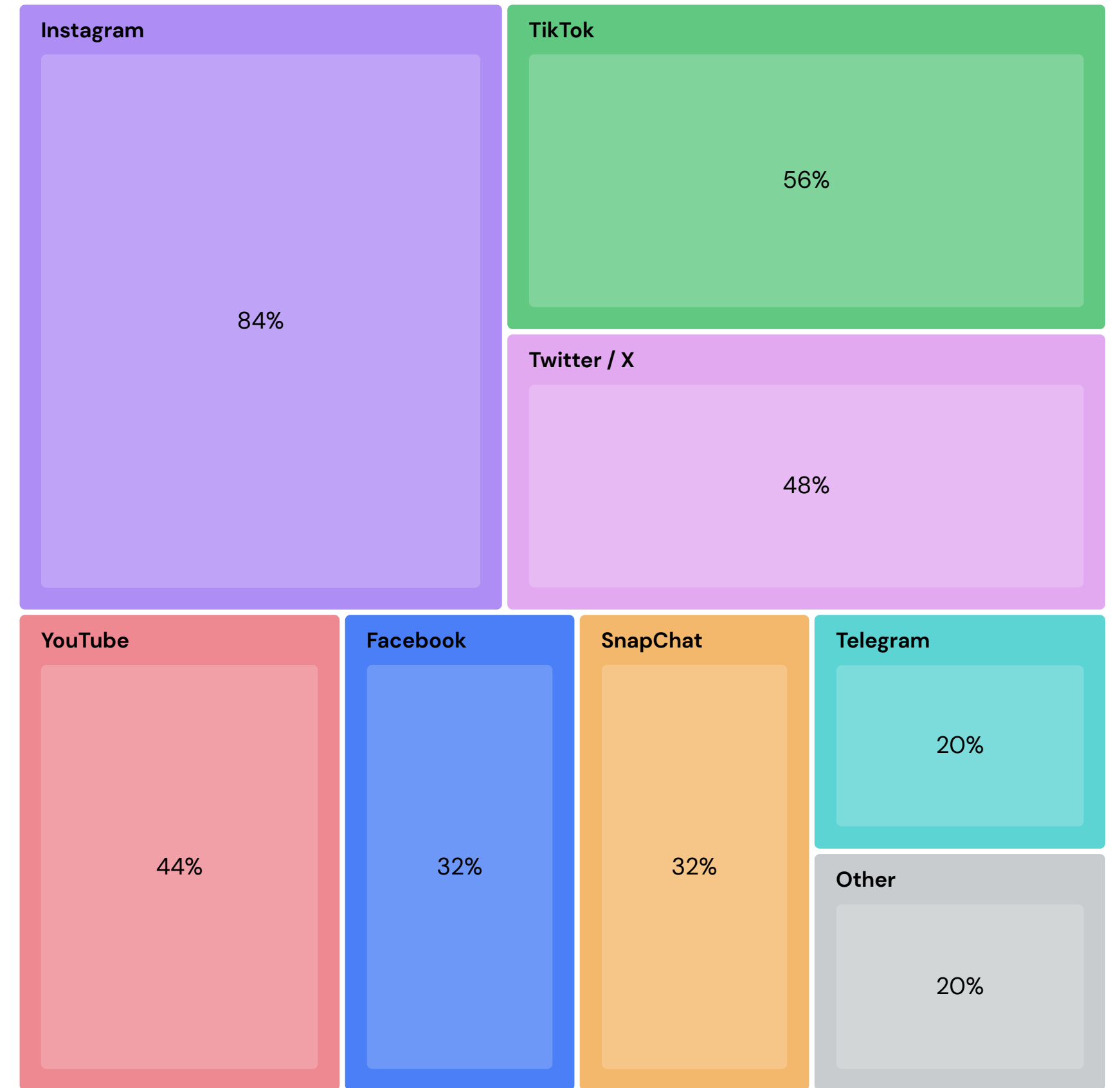
CSAM Exposure Is Not Rare

53.2%

of respondents confirmed a CSAM encounter
(*n* = 50 of 94)

Content Types Encountered

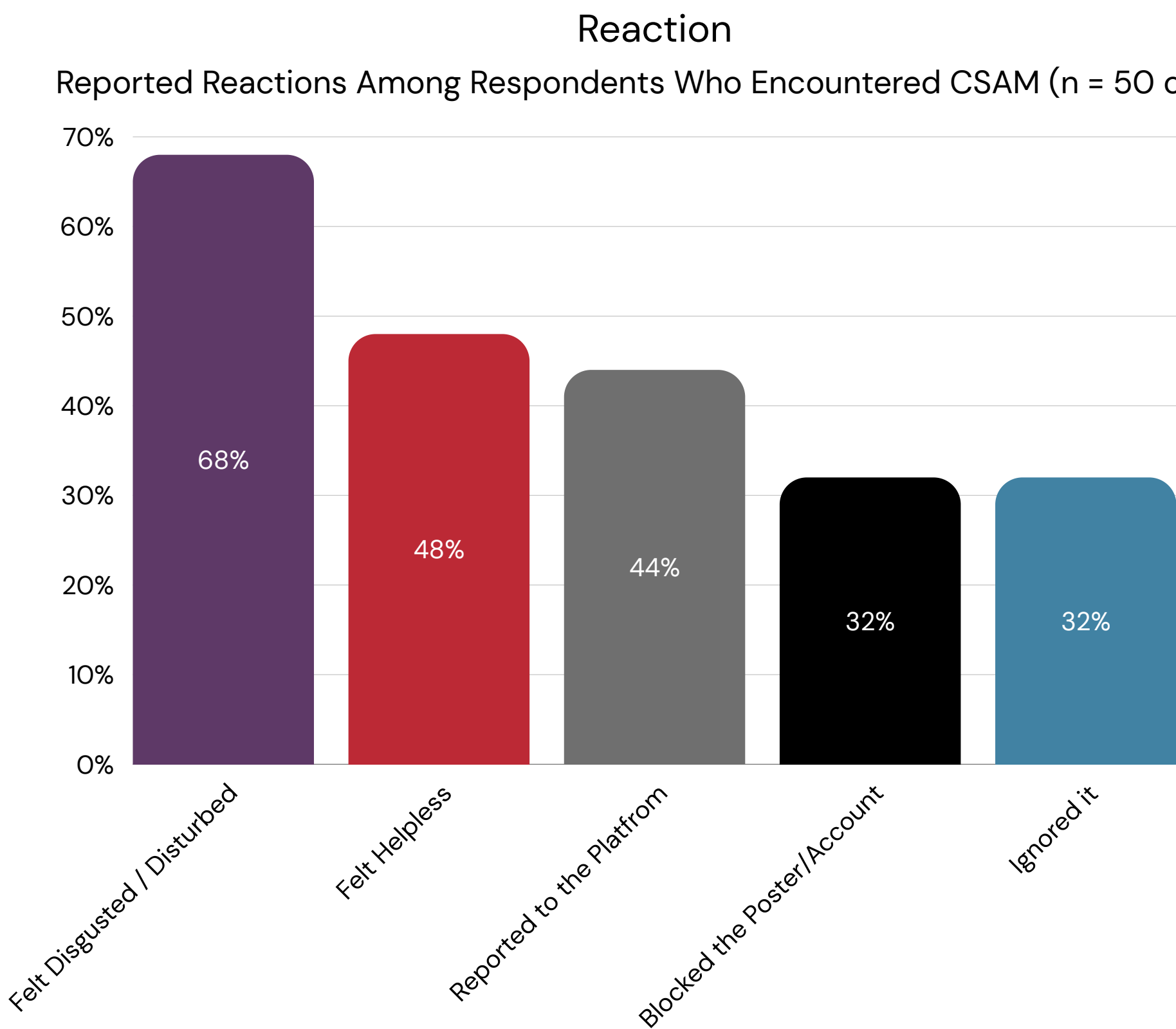
- Explicit video and image depictions of minors being sexually assaulted
- Animated/illustrated sexual content depicting characters identified as minors
- Children in non-sexual contexts accompanied by sexualising comments
- Parent-managed accounts described as venues for exploitation
- Grooming-adjacent comments directed at minors¹



¹ Open-response items; consistent with inclusive CSAM definition per Teunissen & Napier, AIC (2022)

Finding 02

Helplessness over Indifference



Co-occurrence pattern

12 of 16 respondents who ignored the content also reported feeling helpless.

Seligman's learned helplessness framework predicts this pattern: perceived futility of response produces passive non-intervention even when the individual recognises the severity of the situation.^{1 2}

Disgust (68%) is an ambivalent motivational state

It can channel into empathic anger that motivates reporting, or into aversive arousal that motivates avoidance. Which pathway activates depends on whether the bystander believes intervention will accomplish anything.³

The near-universal seriousness rating (mean: 8.11/10, n = 94) confirms that moral recognition of the harm is broadly shared. The activation of action is what breaks down.^{4 5}

¹ Seligman (1975)
² Wong, Cheung & Xiao (2016)
³ Steinvik, Duffy & Zimmer-Gembeck, International Journal of Bullying Prevention (2023)
⁴ Seligman (1975)
⁵ Jeyagobi et al. (2022)

Finding 03

Reporting Gap

80%

Knew how to report
(*n* = 40 of 50)

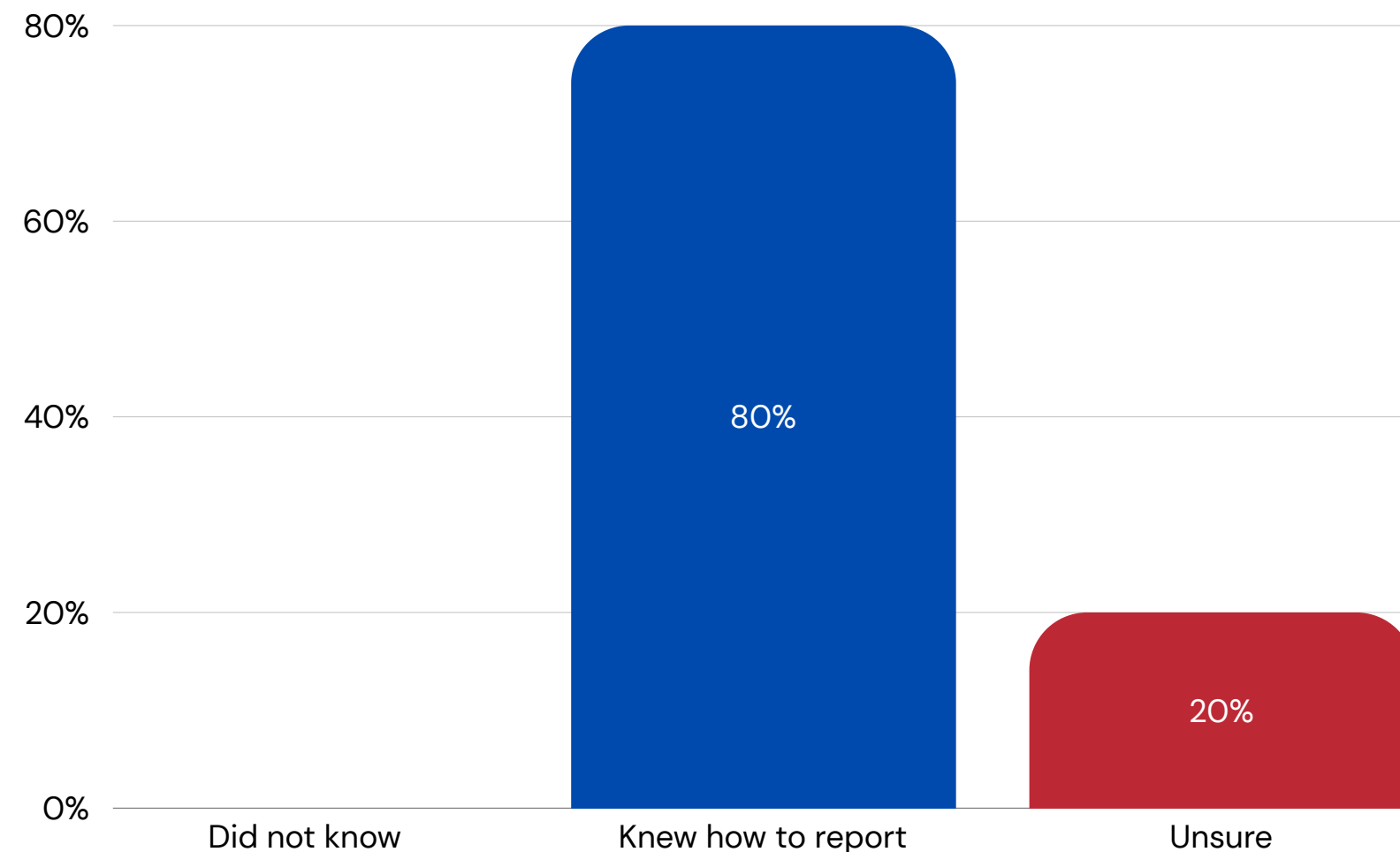
36-point gap

44%

Actually reported
(*n* = 22 of 50)

Reporting Knowledge

None of the 50 encountering respondents definitively lacked reporting knowledge



Reporting effectiveness rated 4.29/10 (SD: 2.07) across the full sample (*n* = 94), including respondents who had never used the reporting system.

No meaningful difference in effectiveness ratings between those who had and had not reported. Low perceived effectiveness is a population-level belief, rather than an outcome of direct experience.

Vahed et al. (2024): in an experimental study (*n* = 294), trait empathy predicted reporting, but trust in platforms was negatively associated with reporting decisions. This suggests pre-existing platform distrust suppresses reporting independently of personal experience.¹

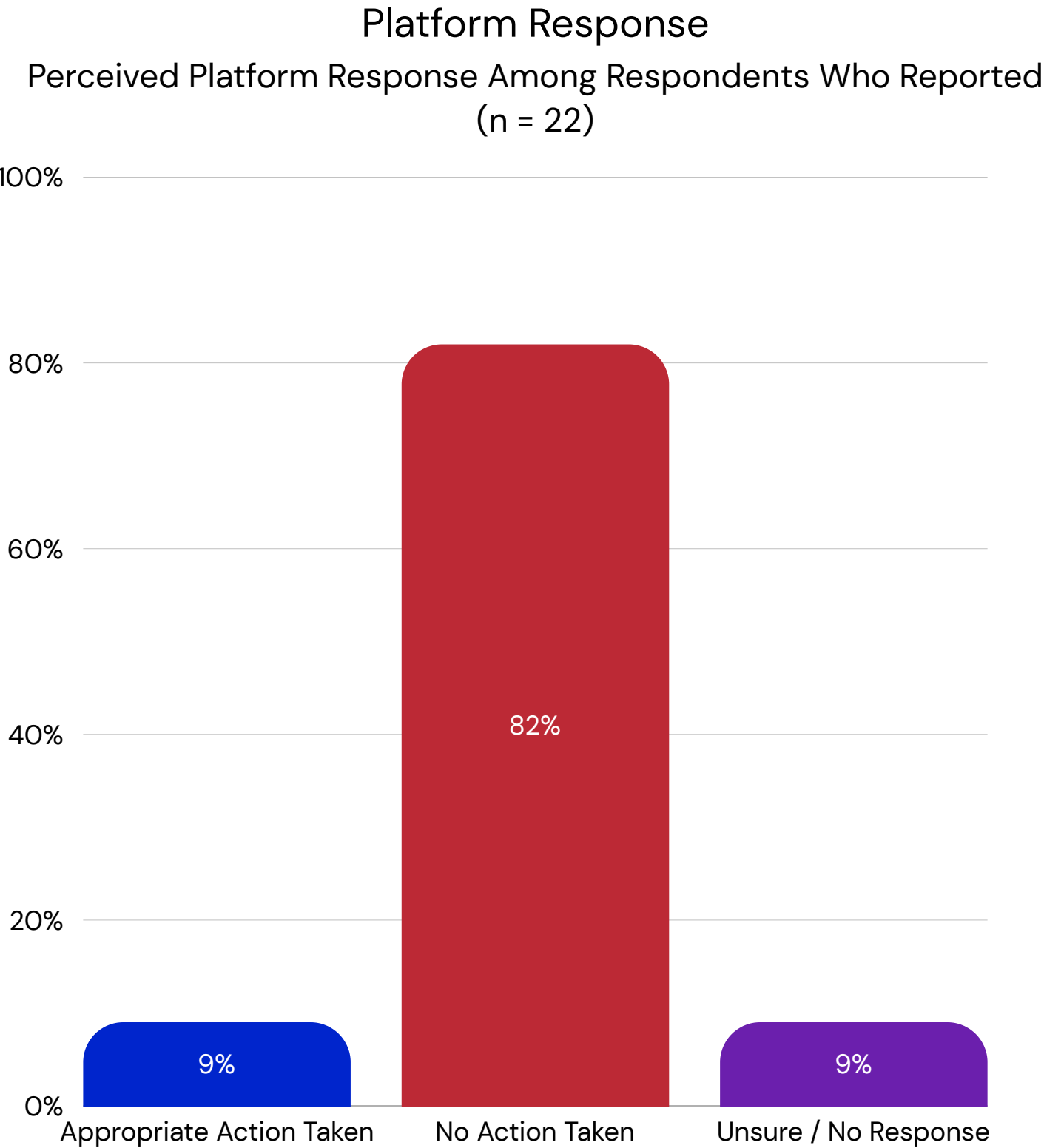
Wong et al. (2016): perceived *reporting efficacy* is the primary predictor of reporting behaviour on social networking sites, more so than reporting knowledge.²

¹ Vahed, Goanta, Ortolani & Sanfey, PLOS ONE (2024)

² Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)

Finding 04

Inadequate Platform Response / Feedback



“Never heard back...”

— Survey respondent, 2024

Of the 50 who encountered CSAM: only 2 (4%) both filed a report and believed the platform acted appropriately.

Platform Adequacy
(n = 94)

Mean 2.40 / 5

(1 = platforms do enough;
5 = platforms do not do enough)

Reporting Effectiveness
(n = 94)

Mean 4.29 / 10 SD: 2.07

No meaningful difference between those who had and had not used the reporting system.

Low perceived effectiveness is a population-level belief, independent of personal reporting experience.

The futility belief is acquired and transmitted through platform signals and social information, alongside through direct personal experience. A user who has formed a prior belief that platform moderation is unresponsive carries that belief into any future encounter, suppressing reporting even when full procedural knowledge is present.^{1 2 3}

¹ Seligman (1975)
² Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)
³ Tian, Chen & Zhang, Applied Sciences (2022)

Finding 05

What Respondents Want From Platforms

Strong consensus for stringent accountability

Content takedown and account suspension command 85% support. Only 34% support a warn-and-allow approach.

These preferences align poorly with current platform practice, in which the majority of electronic service providers do not file NCMEC reports at all.¹

¹ NCMEC, 2024 CyberTipline Report (2024)
² Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)
³ House of Commons, Canada. Bill C-63 (2024)
⁴ U.S. Congress. STOP CSAM Act, S.1829 (2025)

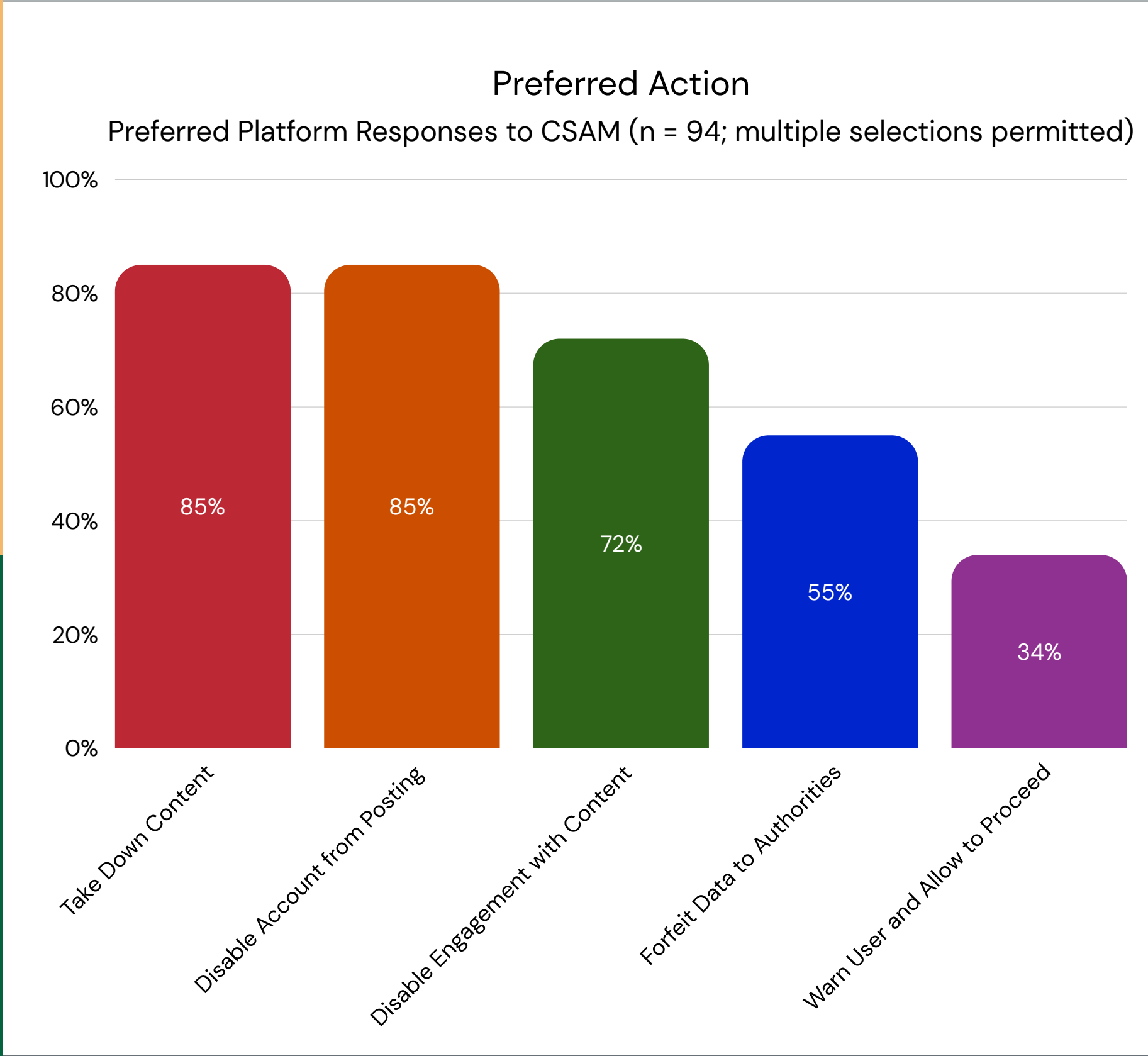
75%

expressed some openness to further education on CSAM reporting.

However, this receptiveness is conditional, as educational campaigns must be paired with credible evidence that reporting produces outcomes, as the problem documented here is distrust of their efficacy, rather than ignorance of mechanisms.²

Notably, respondents' top preferences correspond to the obligations that both Bill C-63 and the STOP CSAM Act proposed to impose.

This suggests that the accountability frameworks users want are the same ones legislators have independently identified as necessary.^{3 4}



Research Implications

¹ Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)

² Scaffidi Abbate et al., Frontiers in Psychology (2022)

³ Batson, Altruism in Humans (2011)

⁴ Teunissen & Napier, AIC (2022)

1 *The feedback loop gap as a research object*

This study documents that 81.8% ($n=18$ of 22) reporters received no visible platform response, and that low perceived effectiveness is a population-level belief independent of direct experience. Whether closing this feedback loop, through platform design or regulatory mandate, would change reporting behaviour over time remains an open empirical question. Future longitudinal research is needed to test this.¹

2 *The literacy-to-behaviour translation problem*

The 36-point gap between reporting knowledge and reporting behaviour suggests that digital literacy interventions alone are insufficient. Research into what conditions activate existing reporting knowledge, including interface design that frames reporting as a direct act of victim protection, may reveal mechanisms that educational campaigns currently miss.^{2 3}

3 *The generalisability of reporting disenchantment*

This study is limited to a single institution with a strong Faculty of Mathematics skew. Whether the reporting gap and associated futility beliefs replicate in broader, more demographically diverse populations, and whether they persist in jurisdictions with stronger platform accountability regimes, are questions this study cannot answer but future research should address.⁴

Limitations

01. Sample Size & Scope

$n = 94$; single institution; convenience sample; may not be proper representation of the UWaterloo student population.

02. Faculty Skew

Faculty of Mathematics over-represented at 48.9%. This may affect generalisability of findings.

03. Self-Report Bias

Sensitive behavioural items, particularly reporting behaviour, may be subject to social desirability effects.

04. Temporal Scope

The survey predates the era of AI-generated CSAM. The IWF (2026) documents 8,029 AI-generated images and videos identified in 2025, with AI abuse videos rising from 13 to 3,440 in a single year. This is a category entirely absent from this instrument.¹

05. Causal Inference

Cross-sectional design does not permit causal inference. The association between helplessness and non-reporting may reflect pre-existing platform distrust rather than encounter-specific responses.²

06. CSAM Definition Scope

The inclusive definition may have broadened the exposure estimate relative to narrower legal definitions. However, it is consistent with prior research on user-side exposure.²

¹ Internet Watch Foundation, Harm Without Limits (2026)

² Teunissen & Napier, AIC (2022)

Future Directions

01. Multi-Institution Replication

Larger, geographically diverse sample to test generalisability of the 36-point reporting gap.

02. AI-CSAM Instrument Update

Explicit treatment of AI-generated CSAM as a distinct exposure and reporting category, given the IWF's documented 26,362% increase in AI abuse videos between 2024 and 2025.¹

¹ Internet Watch Foundation, Harm Without Limits (2026)

² Teunissen & Napier, AIC (2022)

³ U.S. Congress. STOP CSAM Act, S.1829 (2025)

⁴ Scaffidi Abbate et al., Frontiers in Psychology (2022)

03. Longitudinal Design

Does closing the platform feedback loop change reporting behaviour over time?

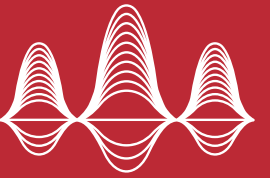
A longitudinal study comparing reporting rates before and after mandatory outcome notification, where implemented, would directly test this study's central inference.

04. Policy Comparison

Jurisdictions where reporter notification is already required, like the EU Digital Services Act (Article 16) and the STOP CSAM Act (if enacted) offer natural comparison cases for whether accountability mechanisms change user behaviour.³

05. Platform Interference Design Studies

Experimental work on whether reframing reporting as a direct act of victim protection activates altruistic motivation sufficient to offset diffusion of responsibility. This builds on Scaffidi Abbate et al.'s (2022) finding that prosocial priming can partially offset the bystander effect in virtual environments.⁴



Conclusion & Key Takeaways

Among University of Waterloo students who encountered CSAM on social media, 80% knew how to report and 44% did. Of those who reported, one in eleven believed the platform took appropriate action.

These findings, set against 36.2 million NCMEC CyberTipline reports¹ and over 40,000 Cybertip.ca reports² in 2023, and against a Canadian legislative landscape in which Bill C-63's enforceable reporter-notification obligations died on the order paper,³ indicate that the user-side dimension of CSAM governance is shaped primarily by distrust of reporting outcomes, more so than ignorance of reporting mechanisms.⁴

This study contributes an empirical account of the user-side experience of CSAM reporting: the gap, the helplessness, and the absent platform feedback that are largely missing from the governance literature.

¹ NCMEC, 2024 CyberTipline Report (2024)

² CyberTip.ca, Reports From the Public Processed in 2023 (2024)

³ House of Commons, Canada. Bill C-63 (2024)

⁴ Wong, Cheung & Xiao, HICSS '16, IEEE (2016)

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